Colour for your website and business

Yes, mainly where you promise depth, expertise or calm. But indigo is not a promise for free.

In business indigo is a colour that **does not shout and is still seen**. It acts like a person who does not have to raise their voice to be listened to. It is deep, expert and a little mysterious, and that is why it is good to know what it promises before you let it into a logo, a website or an advertisement.

By itself, though, it does not attract customers like a magnet. It can help create **a trustworthy impression**, but what mainly decides is still what you sell, to whom and how well it all works together.

What we are telling the customer

Indigo can say, for example

"Things are done properly here." "I do not have to shout." "I have time for your opinion." "It is personal."

- **Depth and expertise.** A dark, calm blue seems trustworthy. The customer reads that things are done properly here.
- **Wisdom and prestige.** Quiet luxury brands use it as a colour of quality that does not have to stress itself.
- **Everydayness.** It is the colour of jeans and therefore of work and comfort. It can be prestigious and ordinary at once.
- **Mystery.** It is linked with night, dream and the inner world. It suits where you offer an experience, not a thing.
- **Distance.** It is a cold and dark colour. When you do not balance it with warmth, it can seem aloof.

Depending on the shade, though, it can also act differently. Midnight is **prestigious and calm**, denim **everyday and friendly**, dusk (light) **gentle and dreamy**, grey indigo **sober and elegant**.

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Simple tips

As a base, not as a wall

It suits as the main colour of a logo or text, because it is legible on a light background. For large areas mute it and balance it with light.

Shade by role

Midnight and dark for prestige and calm, denim for everydayness, dusk for tenderness and dreams, grey indigo for sobriety and elegance.

Combinations

Gold or silver for prestige, white for clarity, yellow and orange for warmth, pink for tenderness.

Cultural context

In Japan indigo is a traditional colour of elegance, in India and in America it also carries a story of forced labour, in the New Age it is linked with intuition. Find out what it means for you and for them.

Legibility

For ordinary text a contrast of at least 4.5 to 1 is recommended (the WCAG accessibility rule). A dark background with dark text is illegible, put dark on light and vice versa.

Colour blindness

About 1 in 12 men has trouble telling red and green apart. Do not use these two colours as the only difference between two things.

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Professions where it is a Yes

Research, education and consulting

Indigo can accompany a thoughtful and calm presentation. Let it stand out on headings or smaller areas. If you offer personal work, also add your own face and understandable words. **Expertise does not have to look like a room where you are afraid to ask anything.**

Therapy, coaching, meditation and sleep

Indigo can be an understandable symbol of an inner view. A visitor, though, also needs to find out what, when, where and for how much. Intuition can have room, searching for the sign-up form does not have to be her final exam.

Writing, art, photography and music

A deep ground can let a work or photograph stand out. But if an indigo filter covers everything, the colour starts to tell mainly about itself. Keep the real shades of the work.

Textiles, denim, indigo printing and craft

Here indigo connects directly to the material and its history. **The colour does not have to pretend a story. The product already has one.** It can be a natural part of a label, packaging and a website. Give room to details of the fabric and the real way of working.

Professions where it is a No

It is not a ban on the colour. Amount and context decide. Here I would go easy on large areas.

- **Loud and cheerful brands.** Children's play, entertainment, fast food, sales and everywhere you need to catch attention at once. Indigo will be too serious.
- **Services where the customer needs to feel warmth and closeness first.** A dark tone alone can seem more serious than you want.
- **Small dark spaces.** A dominant indigo can strengthen a closed-in impression.
- **Crisis and orientation information.** Clarity takes precedence over a mysterious atmosphere.
- **Presentation of food, skin and colour-sensitive products.** Coloured light or a filter can distort the look.
- **Long texts.** They need well readable contrast and enough space.

The rule is simple. When you sell depth, expertise and calm, indigo will help you. When you sell cheerfulness and quick decisions, it will be too serious.

Before you send it into the world

Show the design to a woman who does not know your offer and ask “What would you expect from such a place or service?” **Is the offer visible, or mainly the indigo?** Her answer may tell you more than the general rule that indigo means depth and intuition.

A question for you

“What should your customer feel first when she looks at your website?”

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Examples from the market

You know indigo from jeans and payment cards. Here are **a few examples** that show what it can do.

- **Levi's (jeans)**
  On 20 May 1873 Levi Strauss and the tailor Jacob Davis obtained a patent for metal rivets in work trousers. Jeans are classically dyed with indigo. Aha. A colour that changes over time is part of the magic. Jeans “adapt” to a person.

- **Visa (payments)**
  The name Visa arose in 1976 and the brand kept the blue-white-gold flag. According to the company, blue and gold were meant to recall the blue sky and golden hills of California. Aha. A colour can also carry the place a brand comes from.

- **G-Star RAW (jeans)**
  The company was founded in Amsterdam by Jos van Tilburg in 1989. In 1996 came jeans from unwashed and untreated denim, so-called raw denim. Aha. Raw fabric changes as you wear it and every pair eventually becomes different.

- **Wrangler (jeans)**
  Jeans for cowboys were introduced by the Blue Bell company in 1947. The model was later called 13MWZ after the weight of the denim, 13 ounces per yard. The name was chosen by employees in a competition. Aha. Blue denim carries work and durability here.

What they share is that indigo carries a simple message. **Reliability, calm, craft**. And durability is the best advertising. A colour that lasts gains trust without words.

Colours in business are not law. Studies are mixed and a lot depends on context, customers and how consistent a brand is. Take it as an idea you will check, not as a rule. The brand examples are publicly known and the facts about them come from public sources.

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